

Spencer Harris in his Minneapolis Millers days.

Soucheray

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when I was about 5 years old. I remember my dad talking about Spence Harris. He's still great."

"I think I have a record that still stands in the Texas League," Harris said. "I was playing for Shreveport in 1927 and I got 60 doubles that year, the year that Ruth hit 60 home runs. The next year with the Millers I led the American Association with 32 home runs, 138 runs scored and I drove in 127 runs."

"What was the most money you ever made?" Harris was asked.

"Made \$7,500 with the Athletics," Harris said, "but that didn't last long. I was making \$800 a month with the Millers, but that was cut to \$400 a month during the Depression. In those days, a ballplayer couldn't get a job in the winter because a guy figured he'd just get you trained in and off you'd be to spring training. These days, I can't turn on the television without seeing a ballplayer selling me a car or some soap or something."

Harris and Andy Cohen and a couple of other Millers started a restaurant one off-season called the Windup, on 6th St., downtown. Wind up at the Windup the advertisement went and Harris and his partners turned people away.

"And still lost money," Harris said. "Playin' ball was what I was good at."

Harris stayed with the Millers through 1937 and then bounced around in the Pacific Coast League until 1946, when his career finally ended. He would like to have managed, but when he got the chance with Yakima, Wash., he had the misfortune of bossing a group of ballplayers who had just returned from World War II and who were

interested in the more delicate maneuvers of nightlife. He went to work in a defense plant then, returned to Minneapolis in 1956 and sold suits downtown until he retired.

"You know the modern ballplayer complains a lot about travel," Harris said. "It's an overrated hardship. They travel by airplane, air-conditioned airplane, and they stay in air-conditioned hotels. I remember the bus and train rides and I don't know if the modern guy could have survived some of them. I played for Bay City, Mich., in the Michigan-Ontario League where they had a rule of no Sunday games in Canada. We'd play some town in Canada on a Saturday night and use trains and buses to get back to Bay City for a Sunday doubleheader."

"I remember mosquitoes in Beaumont, Texas, that were big enough to carry you away. And I remember trying to get cool by a ceiling fan in Shreveport. The worst heat I ever played in was right here in Minneapolis when it was about 105 for five straight days. People were sleeping on roofs or in the parks. I remember because we played Columbus that week at Nicollet Field and I went home and slept on the roof."

Now Harris spends every summer day at Hiawatha, playing when he gets a ride in a cart, or walking portions of the course with a single club in his hand. On Fridays he rides with Nordstrom during his weekly tournaments.

"Spence Harris is still a hero out here," Nordstrom said. "We have a lot of older guys like that. They sit in the sun and remember their youth and they're heroes to each other, and to all of us."